

What Must Be Protected

Self Architecture and the
Topology of Psychological Threat

Jani Halmetoja

Contact: halmetojamodel@gmail.com

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Self Architecture and the Topology of Psychological Threat

Series: Structural Regulation Framework, Paper 5

Abstract

The Structural Regulation Framework (SRF; Halmetoja, 2026a) models how psychological regulation operates. A companion paper on Compression Profiles (Halmetoja, 2026d) models where representational resolution varies across signal classes. Neither fully explains why specific signals become threatening in the first place — why shame collapses one person but not another, why dependency feels humiliating to one system but ordinary to another, why criticism becomes information for one person and identity threat for another.

The present paper proposes Self Architecture as the missing explanatory layer: the structural organization of the self that determines what kinds of reality can be integrated without defensive collapse. Seven dimensions are proposed: Self-Coherence, Self-Concept Clarity, Worth Contingency, Shame Integration Capacity, Dependency Tolerance, Self–Other Differentiation, and Ontological Self-Continuity. Together these dimensions constitute a vulnerability topology — a structured surface that determines which signal classes become destabilizing and therefore require compression.

The paper further proposes three levels of regulatory stakes: affective (painful but not self-destroying), identity (threatening self-organization), and ontological (threatening felt existence). The level at which a signal threatens the system determines the intensity of defensive compression it produces.

This paper is conceptual and presents no original empirical data. Its contribution lies in formalizing the relationship between self-structure and signal-class-specific compression, generating testable predictions about individual differences in compression profiles, and providing the theoretical foundation for understanding why regulation protects what it protects.

Keywords: self-concept; self-coherence; contingent self-worth; shame; dependency; personality structure; vulnerability; psychological threat; identity

1. Introduction

1.1 The Missing Layer

The Structural Regulation Framework (Halmetoja, 2026a) explains how regulation operates — through holding capacity, processing flexibility, external dependence, externalization timing, and vector direction. A companion paper on Compression Profiles (Halmetoja, 2026d) explains where representational resolution varies — which signal classes compress under activation and how compression distributes across the regulatory topology.

But neither paper fully answers a prior question: why do specific signals become threatening?

Consider: two individuals with comparable general cognitive ability and similar life circumstances may respond to the same interpersonal event — mild criticism, for example — with radically different regulatory

consequences. For one, criticism is information: uncomfortable but integrable. For the other, criticism is identity threat: destabilizing, requiring immediate defensive reorganization.

The difference cannot be explained by SRF parameters alone (both may have similar IRC). It cannot be explained by compression profiles alone (the compression profile describes the pattern but not its cause). Something determines which signals carry sufficient threat to require compression.

The present paper proposes that this something is Self Architecture.

1.2 Core Thesis

Self Architecture describes the structural organization of the self that determines what kinds of reality can be integrated without defensive collapse.

Or more concisely:

Compression shows where perception narrows. Self Architecture shows why narrowing becomes necessary.

1.3 Relationship to the Theory Program

The present paper occupies a specific position in the SRF theory program:

Paper	Question	Layer
1. SRF	How does regulation work?	Mechanism
2. Resolution Resistance	Why does structure resist change?	Dynamics
3. Narcissistic Architecture	What does this look like clinically?	Application
4. Compression Profiles	Where does reality compress?	Processing topology
5. Self Architecture	What is threatened?	Vulnerability topology
6. Ontological Regulation	When existence itself is threatened?	Deep phenomenology

Paper 5 bridges Paper 4 (where compression occurs) and Paper 6 (the deepest level of threat). It answers the question that Paper 4 defers: why do specific signal classes compress in specific individuals?

1.4 Scope

This paper proposes a conceptual architecture. It does not present empirical validation or validated instruments. It draws on established research traditions (self-concept clarity, contingent self-worth, shame, attachment, mentalization, object relations, self psychology) without claiming to replace them. Its contribution lies in proposing a unified structural framework that integrates these diverse traditions into a coherent vulnerability topology.

2. Self Architecture: Definition and Scope

2.1 Definition

Self Architecture refers to the structural organization of the self — specifically, how self-beliefs, self-worth, identity continuity, shame tolerance, dependency experience, and self–other boundaries are maintained under psychological activation.

It is not a single established construct in psychology. Rather, it is a proposed integrative layer built from existing research on self-concept clarity (Campbell et al., 1996), contingent self-worth (Crocker & Wolfe, 2001), shame (Lewis, 1971; Tangney & Dearing, 2002), attachment (Bowlby, 1969), mentalization (Fonagy et al., 2002), and self-coherence (Kernberg, 1975).

2.2 Distinction from Compression Profile

This distinction is critical:

- **Compression Profile** (Paper 4) describes the observable processing topology — where representational resolution is high and where it is compressed.
- **Self Architecture** (this paper) describes the vulnerability topology — what is threatened by full-resolution processing and why certain signal classes become structurally costly.

The compression profile is the output. Self architecture is the generator.

A person compresses shame signals not because shame is inherently unprocessable, but because their self architecture makes shame-relevant information threatening to self-coherence or worth. Another person with different self architecture may process shame at high resolution because their self-structure can tolerate shame without identity collapse.

2.3 Distinction from Self-Concept Content

Self Architecture concerns structure, not content.

The content of the self-concept is what a person believes about themselves (e.g., “I am competent,” “I am lovable,” “I am autonomous”). Self Architecture concerns how those beliefs are organized — how stable they are, how contingent, how tolerant of contradiction, how dependent on external confirmation.

Two people may hold identical self-concept content (“I am competent”) while differing radically in self architecture: one holds this belief flexibly (can tolerate evidence of incompetence without identity collapse), while the other holds it rigidly (any evidence of incompetence threatens the entire self-structure).

3. Seven Dimensions of Self Architecture

The following dimensions are proposed as a provisional framework for characterizing the vulnerability topology of the self. They are not assumed to be orthogonal — partial overlap is expected and acknowledged.

3.1 Self-Coherence

Organizing question: Can the self remain integrated under contradiction?

Self-coherence refers to the capacity of the self-system to maintain integrated organization when confronted with contradictory self-relevant information.

High self-coherence: > “I made a mistake, but I remain myself. I can hold both my competence and my failure.”

Low self-coherence: > “This mistake invalidates me. If I failed here, perhaps nothing about me is real.”

Low self-coherence means that contradictory information threatens the organization of the self rather than merely producing discomfort. This creates structural pressure to compress contradiction-bearing signals.

Research anchors: Self-concept clarity (Campbell et al., 1996), identity coherence (Erikson, 1968), self-continuity (Chandler et al., 2003).

3.2 Self-Concept Clarity

Organizing question: Are self-beliefs clear, stable, and internally consistent?

Self-concept clarity refers to the degree to which self-beliefs are clearly defined, internally consistent, and temporally stable. This dimension directly incorporates the established construct of self-concept clarity (Campbell et al., 1996).

Low self-concept clarity may manifest as unstable identity, contradictory self-beliefs, difficulty describing oneself consistently, or susceptibility to external redefinition.

Research anchors: Self-concept clarity scale (Campbell et al., 1996), identity disturbance (Wilkinson-Ryan & Westen, 2000).

3.3 Worth Contingency

Organizing question: What must remain true for me to feel worthy?

Worth contingency refers to the degree to which self-worth depends on specific domains remaining intact. When worth is highly contingent, threat to the contingent domain produces not merely disappointment but worth collapse.

Candidate worth-contingent domains include:

- Admiration (worth depends on being admired)
- Competence (worth depends on performance)
- Morality (worth depends on being good)
- Attractiveness (worth depends on being desired)
- Attachment (worth depends on being loved)
- Status (worth depends on rank)
- Autonomy (worth depends on independence)

High worth contingency means that threat to the contingent domain activates not merely negative affect but structural self-worth destabilization. This creates intense pressure to compress signals that threaten the contingent domain.

Research anchors: Contingencies of self-worth (Crocker & Wolfe, 2001), narcissistic vulnerability (Pincus & Lukowitsky, 2010).

3.4 Shame Integration Capacity

Organizing question: Can shame be experienced without identity collapse?

Shame integration capacity refers to the degree to which shame affect can be experienced, tolerated, and processed without producing identity-level destabilization.

High shame integration: > “I feel exposed and regretful, but I can repair. Shame is painful but survivable.”

Low shame integration: > “I am defective, humiliated, or annihilated. Shame is not an emotion — it is what I am.”

When shame integration capacity is low, shame-bearing signals become existentially threatening rather than merely painful. This produces severe compression of shame-relevant signal classes.

Research anchors: Shame and guilt (Tangney & Dearing, 2002), shame-proneness (Lewis, 1971), internalized shame (Cook, 1994).

3.5 Dependency Tolerance

Organizing question: Can conscious dependency be survived?

Dependency tolerance refers to the degree to which the system can acknowledge and tolerate its own reliance on others without experiencing this acknowledgment as identity-threatening.

High dependency tolerance: > “I need others sometimes, and this does not destroy me. Needing is human.”

Low dependency tolerance: > “Needing others means humiliation, weakness, or loss of self. Dependency is annihilation.”

When dependency tolerance is low, dependency-relevant signals (need, vulnerability, reliance, help-seeking) become threatening to self-organization. This produces compression of the dependency signal class and may generate the Dependency Double Bind described in earlier papers (Halmetoja, 2026b, 2026c).

Research anchors: Dependency (Bornstein, 1992), counter-dependency, self-sufficiency as defense (Bowlby, 1980).

3.6 Self–Other Differentiation

Organizing question: Can self and other remain distinct without collapse?

Self–other differentiation refers to the capacity to maintain clear boundaries between self-experience and other-experience, particularly under relational activation.

High differentiation: > “You are separate from me, and I remain myself. Your autonomy does not threaten my coherence.”

Low differentiation: > “Your separateness threatens my existence. Your autonomy means my abandonment.”

When differentiation is low, separateness-relevant signals (the other’s independence, disagreement, or emotional distance) become threatening because they expose the boundary between self and other — a boundary the system may not be able to tolerate.

Research anchors: Differentiation of self (Bowen, 1978; Skowron & Friedlander, 1998), self–other boundary (Kernberg, 1975), individuation.

3.7 Ontological Self-Continuity

Organizing question: Can I remain experientially real without external recognition?

Ontological self-continuity refers to the degree to which the felt sense of existing as a real, continuous self is maintained independently of external confirmation.

High ontological continuity: > “I exist even when I am unseen. My reality does not depend on being witnessed.”

Low ontological continuity: > “If I am not seen, I disappear. Without recognition, I am not real.”

This dimension is the most speculative of the seven. It is introduced here provisionally and developed more fully in a planned companion paper on ontological regulation (Paper 6). Its inclusion in the present framework reflects clinical observations suggesting that some regulatory architectures defend not merely against painful affect or identity threat, but against felt non-existence.

Research anchors: Ontological insecurity (Laing, 1960), going-on-being (Winnicott, 1960), annihilation anxiety (Hurvich, 2003), fragmentation (Kohut, 1971), ontological security as continuity and meaning (Giddens, 1991).

3.8 Construct Boundaries and Discriminant Validity

A critical question concerns whether the seven proposed dimensions are genuinely distinct or merely relabeled adjacent constructs. The following table specifies the proposed discriminant boundaries:

Dimension	What it IS	What it is NOT	Discriminant test
Self-Coherence	Can contradictory self-information be held simultaneously?	Not self-esteem level, not mood stability	Person with high self-esteem may still fragment under contradiction
Self-Concept Clarity	Are self-beliefs clear and stable?	Not self-coherence (clarity $\neq$ integration under contradiction)	Person may have clear self-beliefs that shatter under challenge (clear but brittle)
Worth Contingency	What domains must remain intact for worth?	Not global self-worth level	Person may have high self-worth that is entirely contingent on one domain
Shame Integration	Can shame be experienced without identity collapse?	Not shame frequency, not shame avoidance	Person may experience frequent shame but integrate it (high frequency, high integration)
Dependency Tolerance	Can need be acknowledged without self-threat?	Not actual dependency level, not attachment style	Person may be highly dependent but intolerant of acknowledging it

Dimension	What it IS	What it is NOT	Discriminant test
Self–Other Differentiation	Can other’s separateness be tolerated?	Not social skill, not empathy	Person may be highly empathic but poorly differentiated (fusion-based empathy)
Ontological Self-Continuity	Does felt existence persist without external confirmation?	Not self-esteem, not identity clarity	Person may have clear identity and high self-esteem but externally contingent felt reality

The framework acknowledges that these dimensions are likely correlated — particularly self-coherence, shame integration, and worth contingency. Whether they prove empirically separable or collapse into fewer latent factors remains the most important measurement question for this paper. The seven-dimension structure is proposed for theoretical completeness; empirical investigation may reveal a more parsimonious structure.

3.9 Why Seven Dimensions Rather Than a Single Global Self-Stability Factor

A reviewer may reasonably ask: if these dimensions are correlated, why not propose a single “self-stability” factor?

The answer is predictive specificity. A global factor predicts that all forms of self-threat produce equivalent destabilization. The seven-dimension model predicts that different individuals are vulnerable to *different* threats depending on their specific architectural configuration:

- Person A: high worth contingency on admiration, low shame integration → destabilizes under criticism but tolerates dependency
- Person B: low dependency tolerance, low self–other differentiation → destabilizes under intimacy but tolerates criticism
- Person C: low ontological self-continuity → destabilizes under recognition withdrawal but tolerates status threat

A single global factor cannot generate these differential predictions. The seven-dimension model can — and these predictions are testable through within-subject activation paradigms.

The framework explicitly accepts that factor-analytic investigation may reduce seven dimensions to fewer latent factors. If so, the reduced structure should still preserve differential prediction across threat types. If all dimensions collapse into a single factor with no differential predictive value, the seven-dimension model is falsified and should be replaced by a simpler architecture.

4. Three Levels of Regulatory Stakes

4.1 The Stakes Determine the Intensity

Not all psychological threats are equal. The present framework proposes that the level at which a signal threatens the system determines the intensity of defensive compression it produces.

4.2 Level 1 — Affective Stakes

Characteristic experience: “This hurts.”

At this level, the signal produces painful affect — anxiety, sadness, anger, shame as emotion — but does not threaten the organization of the self. The self remains intact; the experience is unpleasant but integrable.

Examples: - Disappointment after a minor setback - Sadness after a loss - Anger at unfair treatment - Mild embarrassment

Regulatory requirement: affect tolerance. Standard emotion regulation processes are typically sufficient.

4.3 Level 2 — Identity Stakes

Characteristic experience: “This threatens who I am.”

At this level, the signal threatens the structural organization of the self — self-coherence, worth, or identity continuity. The experience is not merely painful but destabilizing to self-organization.

Examples: - Worth collapse following failure in a contingent domain - Self-coherence threat from contradictory self-evidence - Shame that fuses with identity (“I am defective”) - Status injury that threatens hierarchical self-positioning

Regulatory requirement: structural holding capacity (IRC). Standard affect regulation may be insufficient because the threat is organizational, not merely affective.

4.4 Level 3 — Ontological Stakes

Characteristic experience: “This threatens continuity of being.”

At this level, the signal threatens the felt continuity of being itself — the experiential sense of existing as a real, continuous self. The experience is not merely painful or destabilizing — it threatens the ongoing sense of being real.

Examples: - Annihilation anxiety following withdrawal of recognition - Felt unreality when unseen or unmirrored - Disappearance of experiential self-continuity - Collapse of the sense of being real

Regulatory requirement: ontological scaffolding. Neither affect regulation nor standard holding capacity may be sufficient because the threat is existential rather than organizational.

4.5 Stakes and Compression Intensity

The framework proposes a relationship between stake level and compression intensity:

Stake level	Threat type	Compression intensity	Resistance to decompression
Affective	Painful experience	Mild to moderate	Low — standard processing often sufficient
Identity	Self-organization threat	Moderate to severe	High — requires IRC + scaffolding

Stake level	Threat type	Compression intensity	Resistance to decompression
Ontological	Continuity-of-being threat	Severe to total	Very high — may require ontological scaffolding

This predicts that signal classes threatening continuity of being will show the most severe compression and the strongest resistance to therapeutic decompression.

5. Self Architecture as Compression Generator

5.1 The Bridge

Paper 4 (Compression Profiles; Halmetoja, 2026d) describes the observable pattern: which signal classes are compressed and to what degree. The present paper proposes the generative mechanism: self architecture determines which signals become threatening, and therefore which signals require compression.

The logical relationship is directional:

Self Architecture (Paper 5)
 ↓ determines what is threatening
 Compression Profile (Paper 4)
 ↓ determines where resolution drops
 SRF Mechanism (Paper 1)
 ↓ determines how regulation operates
 Observable Behavior

Without Paper 5, Paper 4 describes pattern without explanation — it shows *that* shame compresses but not *why* shame is threatening for this specific individual. Without Paper 4, Paper 5 describes vulnerability without observable consequence — it shows *what* is threatened but not *how* that threat manifests in processing architecture.

Together they form a complete explanatory chain: self architecture generates the vulnerability surface → vulnerability determines which signals are costly → costly signals compress → compression produces the observable processing topology.

5.2 Signal-to-Dimension Mapping

Different signal classes threaten different dimensions of self architecture:

Signal class	Primary self-architecture dimensions threatened
Shame	Worth contingency + Self-coherence + Shame integration
Dependency	Dependency tolerance + Autonomy-contingent worth
Rejection	Attachment-contingent worth + Self-coherence
Separateness	Self–other differentiation + Ontological continuity
Status	Status-contingent worth + Self-coherence

Signal class	Primary self-architecture dimensions threatened
Attachment	Self–other differentiation + Dependency tolerance
Control	Autonomy-contingent worth + Self-coherence
Intent attribution	Self–other differentiation + Self-coherence

This mapping is provisional. The empirical question is whether self-architecture dimensions predict signal-class-specific compression as proposed.

5.3 Why Individuals Differ

Two individuals may differ in compression profiles because they differ in self architecture:

- Person A has high worth contingency on admiration + low shame integration → compresses shame and rejection signals severely
- Person B has low dependency tolerance + low self–other differentiation → compresses dependency and separateness signals severely
- Person C has high self-coherence + high shame integration + moderate worth contingency → compresses minimally across most signal classes

The compression profile is the observable output. Self architecture is the structural explanation for why that specific profile exists in that specific individual.

6. Relationship to Existing Concepts

6.1 Self-Concept Clarity (Campbell et al.)

Self-concept clarity is directly incorporated as Dimension 2. The present framework extends it by embedding it within a broader architectural model that includes worth contingency, shame integration, and ontological continuity — dimensions not captured by self-concept clarity alone.

6.2 Contingent Self-Worth (Crocker & Wolfe)

Contingent self-worth research directly informs Dimension 3 (Worth Contingency). The present framework extends it by proposing that worth contingency determines signal-class-specific compression: the contingent domain predicts which signals will be compressed.

6.3 Shame Research (Lewis, Tangney)

Shame research informs Dimension 4 (Shame Integration Capacity). The present framework distinguishes shame as affect (Level 1 — painful but integrable) from shame as identity fusion (Level 2 — threatening self-organization). This distinction is not always explicit in existing shame literature.

6.4 Self Psychology (Kohut)

Kohut’s concepts of selfobject needs, mirroring, and fragmentation are conceptually consistent with several dimensions — particularly Worth Contingency (admiration-contingent worth), Ontological Self-Continuity

(mirroring as existence maintenance), and Self-Coherence (fragmentation as coherence failure). The present framework reframes these in structural rather than developmental terms.

6.5 Object Relations (Kernberg, Winnicott)

Kernberg's emphasis on splitting and identity diffusion relates to Self-Coherence and Self-Other Differentiation. Winnicott's true self/false self distinction and going-on-being concept relate to Ontological Self-Continuity. The present framework does not contest these formulations but proposes a dimensional structural alternative to categorical object-relational diagnosis.

6.6 Ontological Insecurity (Laing)

Laing's (1960) concept of ontological insecurity — the felt precariousness of one's own existence — directly informs Dimension 7. Laing described ontological security as a "basic existential position" from which a person encounters life's challenges "from a centrally firm sense of his own and other people's reality and identity." The present framework proposes that ontological insecurity is not a global condition or a categorical marker of psychosis (as Laing originally used it) but a dimensional property that varies across individuals and may be activated specifically by recognition-withdrawal signals. Giddens (1991) subsequently extended the concept sociologically as a sense of order and continuity in one's experiences — consistent with the present framework's dimensional treatment.

6.7 Schema Therapy (Young et al.)

Schema therapy proposes Early Maladaptive Schemas — stable self-defeating patterns originating in unmet childhood needs. Several schemas overlap conceptually with Self Architecture dimensions: Abandonment/Instability relates to Self-Other Differentiation and Dependency Tolerance; Defectiveness/Shame relates to Shame Integration; Emotional Deprivation relates to Worth Contingency. The present framework differs in two ways: (1) it proposes dimensions rather than categorical schemas, and (2) it specifies the functional relationship between vulnerability dimensions and signal-class-specific compression — schemas describe content patterns, while Self Architecture describes the structural surface that determines which content becomes threatening.

6.8 Attachment Theory (Bowlby, Mikulincer & Shaver)

Attachment theory proposes that internal working models of self and other shape relational expectations and regulatory strategies. Self Architecture dimensions — particularly Dependency Tolerance, Self-Other Differentiation, and Self-Coherence — overlap substantially with attachment-related constructs. The present framework does not contest attachment theory but proposes a more granular structural decomposition: rather than a single attachment dimension (secure/anxious/avoidant), Self Architecture proposes multiple partially independent vulnerability dimensions that may combine differently across individuals with similar attachment classifications.

6.9 Positioning

The present framework does not replace these traditions. It proposes a structural integration that: - Makes dimensional what was often categorical - Makes measurable what was often narrative - Connects vulnerability structure to observable compression patterns - Generates predictions about individual differences in regulatory architecture

7. Illustrative Application: Narcissistic Organization

A narcissistic self architecture (as described in Halmetoja, 2026c) may be characterized by:

Dimension	Proposed level
Self-Coherence	Fragile
Self-Concept Clarity	Variable (may appear high but contingent)
Worth Contingency	High (admiration, status, competence)
Shame Integration	Low
Dependency Tolerance	Low
Self–Other Differentiation	Unstable
Ontological Self-Continuity	Possibly low

This architecture predicts the compression profile described in Paper 3: severe compression of shame, dependency, rejection, and separateness signals; preserved resolution in status and control signals.

Importantly, grandiosity is not proposed as a core self-architecture dimension. Under this framework, grandiosity is a stabilization strategy — a regulatory output that emerges from fragile architecture rather than a structural feature of the self itself.

8. Testable Predictions

8.1 Self-Coherence Predicts Contradiction Compression

Low self-coherence should predict stronger compression under contradiction-bearing signals. Individuals with fragile self-coherence should show more categorical processing when confronted with self-contradictory information.

8.2 Worth Contingency Predicts Domain-Specific Compression

High worth contingency in a specific domain should predict compression specifically in signal classes that threaten that domain. Admiration-contingent worth should predict shame and rejection compression; competence-contingent worth should predict failure-signal compression.

8.3 Shame Integration Predicts Shame-Channel Degradation

Low shame integration capacity should predict rapid resolution degradation in the shame signal class under mild criticism or exposure conditions.

8.4 Dependency Tolerance Predicts Help-Rejection

Low dependency tolerance should predict defensive responses to help, need acknowledgment, or reliance — even when help is objectively beneficial.

8.5 Self–Other Differentiation Predicts Separateness Distress

Low self–other differentiation should predict distress under autonomy and boundary signals — the other’s independence experienced as threatening rather than neutral.

8.6 Ontological Continuity Predicts Recognition-Withdrawal Destabilization

Low ontological self-continuity should predict extreme destabilization following withdrawal of recognition or mirroring — disproportionate to the social significance of the withdrawal event.

8.7 Stake Level Predicts Compression Intensity

Signal classes threatening continuity of being (Level 3) should show more severe compression and stronger resistance to decompression than signal classes threatening only identity (Level 2) or affect (Level 1).

9. Toward Operationalization

9.1 Measurement Approach

Each dimension may be operationalized through: - Self-report scales (anchored to existing validated measures where possible) - Behavioral paradigms (signal-class-specific activation + response measurement) - Ecological momentary assessment (real-time tracking of self-state stability under naturalistic activation)

9.2 Existing Instrument Anchors

Dimension	Existing measure overlap
Self-Coherence	Identity Disturbance Questionnaire (Wilkinson-Ryan & Westen)
Self-Concept Clarity	Self-Concept Clarity Scale (Campbell et al., 1996)
Worth Contingency	Contingencies of Self-Worth Scale (Crocker et al., 2003)
Shame Integration	Internalized Shame Scale (Cook, 1994) + Experience of Shame Scale
Dependency Tolerance	No direct existing measure — requires development
Self–Other Differentiation	Differentiation of Self Inventory (Skowron & Friedlander, 1998)
Ontological Self-Continuity	No direct existing measure — requires development

9.3 Operational Caveat

These proposals remain preliminary. The present aim is to demonstrate that the framework connects to existing measurement traditions and is empirically approachable. Full instrument development requires dedicated psychometric work beyond the scope of this conceptual paper.

10. Limitations

1. **Conceptual framework only.** No empirical validation is presented.
 2. **Seven dimensions may be too many or too few.** The taxonomy is provisional and may require revision following factor-analytic investigation.
 3. **Dimensional overlap.** Self-coherence, shame integration, and worth contingency are likely correlated. Whether they represent distinct dimensions or facets of a smaller number of latent factors remains unknown.
 4. **Ontological Self-Continuity is speculative.** This dimension has the least empirical grounding and the highest theoretical risk. It is included provisionally.
 5. **Causal direction unclear.** The framework proposes that self architecture generates compression profiles, but the causal direction may be bidirectional — chronic compression may also shape self architecture over time.
 6. **Developmental mechanisms unspecified.** The framework describes current architecture but does not fully explain how it formed. Developmental mechanisms (mirroring, attachment, temperament $\times$ environment) are acknowledged but not formalized.
 7. **Cultural assumptions.** The framework may implicitly privilege Western individualistic self-organization. Whether these dimensions apply universally or require cultural adaptation remains unknown.
 8. **Overlap with existing frameworks.** Substantial overlap exists with self psychology, object relations, and schema therapy. The framework must demonstrate incremental value beyond relabeling.
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11. Summary

Self Architecture formalizes the vulnerability surface that determines which signal classes become destabilizing and therefore require compression. It answers the question that Compression Profiles (Paper 4) defers: why do specific signals compress in specific individuals?

The answer is structural: signals compress because they threaten specific dimensions of self-organization. The nature of the threat — affective, identity-level, or ontological — determines the intensity of compression and the resistance to decompression.

If Paper 4 is the topology of where reality compresses, the present paper is the topology of what reality threatens.

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